Ancient Greece

Ancient Greece is perhaps one of the most famous civilizations from ancient times. Located in southeast Europe, and known as Hellas or Ellada in Greek, it is made up of the mainland and countless islands scattered across the Mediterranean. Ancient Greece saw the birth of astronomy, western philosophy (including Socrates, Aristotle and Plato), literature, mathematics, democracy and even the Olympic Games. Ancient Greece was much more scientific than what we may initially give it credit for: Democritus and Leucippus both put forth their theory of an atomic universe at this time. The Latin alphabet was born in Ancient Greece after the Phoenicians brought it into the country. And don't forget Archimedes who was a pioneer in engineering and physics.

The mainland of Greece is enveloped by the Mediterranean Sea on three sides, with several clusters of islands grouped together. These include the Cyclades, the Dodecanese, the Ionians, Crete and the peninsula area called the Peloponnese. All of these areas had their own identities and cultures at one time before they were grouped into one culture in Ancient Greek history.

The landscape of the country had a deep impact on the culture and identity of Ancient Greece. It had few natural resources on land and was enveloped by water to such an extent that the ocean provided much in the way of resources. Around eighty percent of Greece is actually made up of mountains. The small rivers and streams provide water only suitable for growing crops. As a result, the earliest Greeks took to the sea, establishing colonies on the various islands along modern day Turkey, known in antiquity as Asia Minor. The Ancient Greeks developed a reputation as great seafarers and merchants who traded raw construction materials. From them came great artists who created some of the most awe-inspiring buildings and monuments in history.

Ancient Greek history is usually divided into several eras. During the Paleolithic era the country was already inhabited by people, as indicated by evidence that was found at the Franchthi and the Petralona caves. During